

# 2027 College Pitcher Watch List: Tiering the Top 53 Arms in the Country

Ranking players creates certainty where very little actually exists. A list implies clear separation between neighboring names, even when the gap between them is often negligible. The difference between the No. 11 and No. 12 pitcher in a class can come down to a single pitch, a projected role, or a developmental trait that may look completely different six months from now.

Tiering offers a different lens. Instead of forcing every player into a strict numerical order, it groups pitchers by comparable overall value, upside, and probability. The objective is not to determine whether one arm deserves to be ranked a single spot ahead of another. It is to identify where meaningful breaks exist within the class and which players belong in the same conversation.

That distinction feels especially important in the 2027 college pitching crop. The class features a small group of pitchers with the potential to anchor the top of the board, a larger wave of high-end talent capable of reaching that level, and significant depth extending well beyond the household names. While individual evaluations vary, the broader structure of the class becomes clearer when viewed through tiers rather than rankings.

This list represents a blend of present ability and future projection. Arsenal quality, pitch grades, physical traits, starter indicators, developmental runway, and likelihood of handling meaningful workloads were all considered when determining placement. Statistical performance mattered, but it was evaluated within the context of underlying tools and long-term projection rather than treated as the sole deciding factor.

The result is a snapshot of where the nation's top 53 college arms stand entering the 2027 season. Some will outperform their tier. Others will fall short of expectations. That's the nature of pitching development. For now, however, these five groups provide the clearest picture of how the class separates itself, where the strongest concentrations of talent reside, and which pitchers enter the spring occupying the most valuable ground on the board.

## Tier 1: The Headliners

The highest tier is reserved for pitchers who combine premium talent with realistic starter outcomes. While the members of this group arrive there through very different paths, each possesses at least one trait capable of anchoring a professional profile and enough supporting characteristics to project near the front of a rotation. Some offer louder pure stuff. Others bring greater workload certainty, deeper arsenals, or more advanced strike-throwing ability. The common denominator is impact. Entering the 2027 season, these are the arms most likely to shape the top of the draft conversation.

### Sam Cozart, RHP, Texas

Few pitchers in the country combine Cozart's physicality and arsenal depth. The 6-foot-6 right-hander arrived in Austin as a highly regarded recruit and immediately became one of the most dominant relievers in college baseball, capturing National Stopper of the Year honors while helping power Texas to Omaha. Even in a bullpen role, the long-term appeal always extended beyond the ninth inning.

What separates Cozart from many power relievers is the breadth of the arsenal. The fastball already grades among the best in the class, while the slider, sweeper, and splitter each flash professional quality. That variety gives him far more avenues to attack hitters than a typical bullpen arm and creates a realistic foundation for a starter's workload. The profile is built around more than velocity and raw stuff. It is built around the possibility of turning a dominant closer into a complete starter.

The biggest remaining question revolves around volume rather than talent. Cozart has already proven he can dominate elite competition in short bursts. If the same pitch quality and strike-throwing hold over a full season in the rotation, he has the ingredients to establish himself among the premier pitching prospects in the country.

### Chris Levonas, RHP, Wake Forest

No pitcher in the class combines certainty and upside quite like Levonas. While many elite amateur arms are built around one dominant pitch or one standout physical trait, Levonas brings an

unusually complete package to the mound. He already operates with a legitimate five-pitch mix, throws strikes, misses bats, and has demonstrated the ability to handle a significant workload against high-level competition. There simply are not many college pitchers entering 2027 with as few obvious holes.

The foundation begins with arsenal depth. Levonas attacks hitters with a mid-to-upper-90s fastball, two distinct breaking balls, a cutter, and a changeup, giving him answers against virtually every hitter type and game situation. More importantly, each pitch serves a purpose. Nothing in the repertoire feels like a placeholder offering or a developmental necessity. The slider is the headliner and one of the premier swing-and-miss pitches in the country, but the fastball, curveball, and cutter all carry enough quality to win at-bats on their own. What elevates the profile into the highest tier is how naturally everything fits together. Levonas does not need to rely on maximum effort or perfect execution from a single offering. Instead, he layers different movement profiles, velocity bands, and locations throughout an outing, forcing hitters to continuously adjust. That adaptability gives him one of the safest starter projections in the class and allows the stuff to play consistently deep into games.

There may be pitchers in the class with louder individual tools, but very few can match the blend of repertoire depth, strike-throwing ability, and starter traits Levonas already possesses. Entering the season, he stands as one of the clearest bets in the country to remain a professional starter and has every opportunity to establish himself as a top pick in the '27 class.

### Tomas Valincius, LHP, Mississippi State

Valincius looks the part of a professional starter from the moment he steps on the mound. The frame is built to handle innings, the delivery is repeatable, and the approach is rooted in attacking hitters rather than avoiding contact. Among the pitchers in this class, few have already demonstrated his blend of workload, strike throwing, and pure stuff. When projecting forward, there is significant value in arms that have already proven they can be trusted every weekend, and Valincius has done exactly that.

The profile is built around a devastating sinker-slider combination. The sinker carries mid-90s velocity with heavy arm-side movement, allowing him to generate weak contact, ground balls, and

uncomfortable at-bats against hitters from either side of the plate. It is not simply a setup pitch. It is a weapon capable of dictating the entire at-bat. The slider gives him a legitimate finishing pitch, providing a different movement plane and the swing-and-miss necessary to put hitters away once he gains leverage in the count. Together, the two pitches form one of the most effective pitch pairings in the country.

What stands out from a scouting perspective is how comfortable the starter projection already feels. Valincius does not need evaluators to imagine a future workload or dream on physical development. He has already carried a frontline role, worked deep into games, and maintained both strikeout production and efficiency across nearly 100 innings. Those traits matter. College baseball is full of talented arms, but far fewer demonstrate the durability and consistency expected of a professional starter.

The lingering question is the same one attached to many sinker-slider profiles. Both primary pitches are good enough to succeed against high-level competition, but the continued development of the changeup will determine just how high the ceiling ultimately reaches. There is a difference between a pitcher surviving on two elite offerings and one possessing a complete arsenal capable of turning over professional lineups repeatedly. Even with that remaining developmental checkpoint, Valincius enters the season as one of the safest bets in the class to remain in a rotation and one of the most accomplished starters on the board.

### Dylan Volantis, LHP, Texas

Volantis is one of the more unusual evaluations in the class because so much of his success comes from traits that are difficult to replicate. At 6-foot-6 with a high release point, he creates exceptionally steep angles to the plate and leverages them through a repertoire built around movement, sequencing, and deception rather than pure velocity. The profile is different from many of the power arms near the top of the board, but the results and underlying traits make it one of the more convincing starter looks in the country.

The sinker and curveball drive the evaluation. The sinker creates uncomfortable contact through heavy arm-side movement and downhill plane, allowing him to dictate at-bats early and work

efficiently through lineups. Everything, however, ultimately revolves around the curveball. It is one of the premier pitches in the class, generating elite swing-and-miss while serving as both a strike-stealing weapon and a put-away offering. The combination of shape, command, and release characteristics gives hitters a look they simply do not see very often.

What stands out most on film is how difficult the entire operation is to get comfortable against. The delivery, release height, sinker movement, and curveball shape all work together. There are flashier velocity profiles in the class, but very few pitchers force hitters to solve as many problems within a single at-bat. That ability allowed Volantis to shoulder a frontline workload for Texas while maintaining both strikeout production and run prevention across nearly 100 innings.

The profile is not without risk. Unlike some of the other arms in this tier, Volantis is not built around overpowering velocity or a deep collection of plus offerings. The continued development of the splitter would provide another answer against advanced hitters and further strengthen the starter projection. Even so, the combination of workload, deception, pitchability, and a truly elite carrying pitch gives him one of the strongest overall cases in the class. He may arrive there differently than the others in Tier 1, but he belongs in the same conversation.

## Dax Whitney, RHP, Oregon State

Whitney remains the standard for pure stuff in the 2027 class. Even among a group loaded with future professional starters, few pitchers can match the combination of velocity, pitch quality, and swing-and-miss ability he brings to the mound. The profile is built around power, but it is not a simple two-pitch power arm. There is legitimate depth here, with multiple offerings capable of generating outs and enough athleticism and strike throwing to support a long-term starter projection.

Everything starts with the fastball. Averaging 97 mph with elite carry and extension, it is one of the best individual pitches in the class. Hitters know it is coming and still struggle to handle it. The pitch misses bats at the top of the zone, generates poor contact when challenged in the strike zone, and serves as the foundation for the entire arsenal. Few amateur fastballs combine velocity, shape, extension, and results as cleanly as Whitney's.

The secondary pitches reinforce the profile rather than simply support it. The slider is a true out pitch with power, sweep, and depth, capable of ending at-bats against hitters from either side of the plate. Unlike many power pitchers, Whitney also possesses a legitimate changeup that flashes as an above-average offering and gives him another answer against opposite-handed hitters. The curveball rounds out the mix, creating a different movement plane and further increasing the difficulty of game planning against him. There are very few pitchers in the class who can create swing-and-miss with this many different pitches.

The primary concern is not arsenal quality. It is simply durability and workload. Whitney enters the season recovering from UCL surgery, creating more uncertainty than would normally accompany a pitcher with this level of stuff. If healthy, however, there is little debate about the talent. The fastball is elite, the slider is elite, and the supporting pieces are strong enough to complete the profile. From a scouting perspective, it is difficult to find another arm in the class with a higher pure ceiling.

## Tier 2: Elite Depth

This tier represents the strongest collection of challengers to the class's headliners. Each arm possesses at least one trait that would justify a higher placement, whether that be a carrying pitch, exceptional athleticism, elite velocity, or a starter's track record against high-level competition. What separates this group from Tier 1 is not a lack of talent, but the presence of one remaining question, whether that be role certainty, command consistency, arsenal completeness, or the need to prove success over a larger workload.

In many years, several of these pitchers would have a legitimate argument for the top tier. Entering 2027, they instead form a group of high-end prospects with the talent to force their way into the national spotlight and reshape the conversation around the top of the class.

### Jackson Barberi, RHP, Florida

Barberi's profile is built around power. The fastball explodes through the top of the strike zone, the slider arrives with the type of depth and velocity associated with professional out pitches, and hitters rarely look comfortable against either offering. The remaining development centers on proving the arsenal can handle more responsibility than a high-leverage relief role and continuing to build confidence in the changeup.

### Rhys Bowie, LHP, Wake Forest

Bowie brings the loudest collection of raw weapons outside the top tier. Two distinct fastball looks, a devastating cutter, and arguably the most dominant breaking ball in the class allow him to overwhelm hitters when the delivery and command are synced up. There are still questions about consistency, but few pitchers offer more ways to create swings and misses.

### Zach Edwards, RHP, Oregon State

Edwards is one of the more explosive arms in the class, built around premium velocity and a pair of secondaries that already generate uncomfortable swings. The slider does most of the damage, living beneath barrels and serving as the clear finisher within the arsenal. The question is not whether

the stuff is good enough, but whether he can continue turning raw arm talent into a complete starter profile over larger workloads.

### Aidan King, RHP, Florida

King succeeds through efficiency, command, and an unusually mature understanding of how to attack hitters. The profile is anchored by a quality fastball and four-pitch mix that lacks an obvious weakness, allowing him to handle meaningful innings without relying on one dominant offering. There may be flashier arms in the class, but few enter the season with a stronger foundation for remaining in a professional rotation.

### Ryan McPherson, RHP, Mississippi State

McPherson looks like a starter every time he takes the mound. The athletic delivery, strike throwing, and deep five-pitch mix give him multiple ways to navigate an outing, while the splitter serves as the defining secondary within the profile. He may not possess a singular carrying tool on the level of some names above him, but very few arms in the class offer the same combination of completeness and flexibility.

### Wylan Moss, RHP, UCLA

Moss is driven by one of the most unusual changeups in the country, a pitch that consistently puts hitters in uncomfortable positions and gives him a reliable answer against either handedness. The fastball complements it well, creating a strong two-pitch foundation that already supports a starter projection. The next step is straightforward: continued development of the slider would give the arsenal the depth needed to match the quality of its two headlining pitches.

### Will Sanford, RHP, Oregon

Sanford attacks hitters through a fastball-driven approach that few pitchers in the country can replicate. The combination of elite carry and a power downer curveball creates difficult north-south decisions throughout an at-bat, while the developing changeup offers another avenue for growth. He already owns the workload and strikeout production teams want to see, making continued strike-throwing gains the clearest path toward another tier.

## Tier 3: Everyday Starter / High-Leverage Mix

This tier is where the line between starter and reliever begins to blur. Some of these arms possess stuff comparable to pitchers ranked above them, while others bring proven workloads or starter traits that offset less explosive pure arsenals. The common thread is that each profile contains at least one remaining question preventing a move into the upper tiers, but each also possesses a realistic path toward becoming a meaningful professional arm.

### Tanner Bradley, RHP, Oregon

Bradley's changeup remains one of the defining pitches in the entire class and drives the evaluation. The question is whether the sinker-sweeper combination develops enough support around it to maintain a starter projection.

### Camden Clark, RHP, Southern Miss

A quality fastball-changeup pairing forms the foundation of Clark's profile, giving him a reliable weapon against hitters from both sides of the plate. The remaining growth comes from sharpening the breaking ball mix and proving the arsenal can consistently miss bats against higher-end competition.

### Troy Dressler, RHP, Wake Forest

Dressler attacks with a quality riding fastball and a pair of steep breaking balls that generate more swing-and-miss than his results might suggest. Finding a more reliable answer against right-handed hitters would go a long way toward strengthening the starter projection.

### Casan Evans, RHP, LSU

Evans is built around one of the most effective splitters in the class, a pitch that consistently generates chase, swing-and-miss, and ground-ball contact when located beneath the zone. The profile still needs more consistent strike throwing and run prevention, but the splitter gives him a carrying trait that keeps the starter projection alive despite the volatility elsewhere in the arsenal.

## Cole Gibler, LHP, Arkansas

Gibler wins through angles, deception, and a pair of secondaries that consistently create uncomfortable swing decisions. The slider-changeup combination gives him a strong starter foundation, but continuing to improve the fastball's effectiveness against right-handed hitters remains a key developmental checkpoint.

## Easton Hawk, RHP, UCLA

Hawk possesses the type of velocity and athleticism that immediately draw attention, and his slider already looks capable of carrying a professional role. A successful transition into a larger workload would elevate the profile considerably, especially if the changeup continues progressing.

## Sean Jenkins, RHP, East Carolina

Few pitchers in the class can match the power and violence of Jenkins' sinker-slider combination. The path forward centers on whether a third pitch develops enough to support more than a high-leverage bullpen projection.

## Ethan Lund, LHP, Oklahoma State

Lund pairs a projectable frame with legitimate swing-and-miss stuff, highlighted by one of the better curveballs among left-handed pitchers in the class. Reducing the volatility in the strike throwing would allow the raw arsenal to play much closer to its ceiling.

## Landon Mack, RHP, Tennessee

Mack brings premium velocity, advanced spin traits, and a starter's repertoire built around a powerful sinker-slider foundation. The continued development of the changeup will likely determine whether he settles into a rotation long term.

## Jack Ohman, RHP, Yale

Ohman possesses more pure stuff than many realize, featuring a quality riding fastball, multiple breaking-ball shapes, and an intriguing splitter. Improving overall strike efficiency would allow the arsenal to play closer to its underlying traits.

## William Schmidt, RHP, LSU

Schmidt's slider is among the most impactful individual pitches in this tier and gives him a true bat-missing foundation. Improved command and continued development of the supporting arsenal could quickly move him back into higher conversations.

## Duke Stone, RHP, Mississippi State

Stone still offers one of the deeper repertoires in the class, pairing a quality fastball with a curveball, slider, and splitter that all flash professional utility. The challenge entering 2027 is turning those ingredients into more consistent execution and run prevention.

## Zach Strickland, RHP, UCLA

Strickland thrives on the strength of a riding fastball and a hard slider that already project comfortably at the professional level. The profile works whether he remains in relief or eventually earns an opportunity to start.

## Joshua Whritenour, RHP, Florida

Whritenour's profile is built around pure power, with upper-90s velocity and a devastating cutter doing most of the heavy lifting. The emergence of a trustworthy third pitch would create a much stronger starter argument.

## Tier 4: Priority Follows

This tier is populated by pitchers who possess a carrying trait worth tracking closely, whether it's a standout pitch, unusual release characteristics, physical projection, or a developmental path that could eventually push them into a larger role.

### Kyle Alivo, RHP, Iowa

Alivo combines rare pitch diversity with above-average arm talent, and the challenge entering 2027 is refining a seven-pitch mix into a cohesive starter profile.

### Cameron Bagwell, RHP, Wake Forest

Bagwell's value is driven by a plus changeup that generates chase, weak contact, and uncomfortable swings despite a fastball that still needs refinement.

### Lazaro Collera, RHP, Miami

Collera's sweeper remains the defining trait in the profile, pairing unusual depth and lateral movement with enough velocity to project as a professional out pitch.

### Charlie Foster, LHP, Ole Miss

Foster is built around an excellent split-change and angle-driven four-pitch mix that gives him a viable path to handling hitters from both sides of the plate.

### Nate Harris, RHP, Kentucky

Harris owns a professional frame and a hard slider that flashes bat-missing ability, but the supporting arsenal still has to take a step forward.

### Walker McDuffie, RHP, North Carolina

McDuffie's sinker-sweeper combination creates difficult east-west decisions for hitters and provides a clear blueprint for a future multi-inning role.

### Anderson Nance, RHP, NC State

Nance features both a hard slider and a true sweeper capable of missing bats, making strike throwing the variable that will determine how far the profile climbs.

## Jake Schweitzer, RHP, Louisville

Schweitzer attacks through movement differentials and sequencing, using a firm cutter as the primary bridge between a sinker-heavy approach and his secondary mix.

## Max Stammel, LHP, Virginia

Stammel's low-slot delivery and heavy fading changeup create one of the most uncomfortable visual looks among left-handed starters in the class.

## Cooper Walls, RHP, Florida

Walls leans heavily on a legitimate bat-missing sweeper, with the future value of the profile tied to continued development of the fastball and changeup.

## Noah Wech, RHP, Oklahoma State

Wech's low-spin changeup serves as a true carrying pitch and gives him a weapon that already projects against advanced hitters.

## Henry Zatkowski, LHP, Virginia

Zatkowski's deceptive arm slot, starter's workload, and movement-heavy arsenal allow him to succeed through angles and discomfort rather than raw velocity.

## Tier 5: Late Sleepers / Projects

This tier is driven more by projection, carrying traits, and developmental pathways than complete present-day profiles. Each arm possesses at least one characteristic worth betting on, whether it's a unique pitch shape, physical upside, athleticism, or limited-sample flashes that could look very different one year from now.

### Smith Bailey, RHP, Arizona

Bailey brings a true four-pitch starter mix highlighted by a quality slider and enough frame, spin, and strike-throwing ability to envision a rebound season anchoring Arizona's rotation.

### Mason Brassfield, LHP, TCU

Brassfield's profile is built around a hard, high-spin slider and a durable left-handed frame, with the development of a usable changeup likely determining whether he starts or relieves professionally.

### Trever Baumler, RHP, TCU

Baumler's riding fastball and changeup provide a functional starter foundation, but one of the breaking balls must emerge as a reliable weapon to unlock more value.

### Easton Barrett, LHP, Arizona State

Barrett creates difficult angles through a crossfire operation and already flashes a legitimately interesting slider when he gets it beneath the zone.

### Blaine Brown, LHP, Tennessee

Brown remains a projection-heavy arm whose appeal stems from left-handed velocity, athleticism, and the possibility of eventually carrying four usable pitches.

### Tate DeRias, RHP, Miami

DeRias quietly owns a quality sweeper-changeup combination that misses bats, making strike quality more of a limiting factor than raw stuff.

## Jason Flores, RHP, Georgia

Flores' sinker-cutter combination still shows flashes of professional utility, and a fresh opportunity could help stabilize a profile that never found traction in Austin.

## Noah Franco, LHP, TCU

Franco's power sinker creates difficult contact points from the left side, but the future of the profile depends on developing a trustworthy secondary behind the slider.

## Tyler Guerin, RHP, Iowa

Guerin's heavy running sinker and physical 6-foot-6 frame continue to stand out, even as command inconsistency increasingly points toward a relief future.

## Austin Nye, RHP, Vanderbilt

Nye possesses a legitimate starter's arsenal featuring a riding fastball and quality slider, but ten healthy innings simply leave too much projection in the evaluation.

## John Paone, RHP, Virginia

Paone's low-slot sinker-slider attack creates some of the most uncomfortable east-west angles in the class and already resembles a professional bullpen look.

## Drew Rerick, RHP, Oklahoma

Rerick is almost entirely a projection play today, but a riding mid-90s fastball and hard cutter provide enough raw ingredients to keep evaluators interested.

## Mason Russell, LHP, Arizona

Russell's supination-heavy arsenal and pair of promising breaking balls offer intrigue, though the lack of innings makes the profile difficult to pin down.

## Matthew Shorey, LHP, Vanderbilt

Shorey's deceptive crossfire delivery, low release, and movement-oriented arsenal flashed enough starter traits that health remains the only reason he lands in this tier.

## Cooper Williams, LHP, LSU

Williams pairs a ground-ball-oriented sinker with a quality slider, creating a straightforward but potentially effective professional blueprint from the left side.

## Conclusion

Ten pieces. Fifty-three pitchers. Two hundred and seventeen individual pitches evaluated, graded, and written up one at a time. This series started with a simple premise: that the 2027 college pitching class deserved a closer look than a midseason mock draft could give it. That idea has turned into a full season's worth of work before a single pitch of the actual season was thrown.

It started with the pitches themselves. The fastball piece established the traits that separate a hard one from a good one, Whitney's carry, Bowie's deceptive angle, Cozart's conviction attacking the top of the zone. The breaking ball and offspeed pieces did the same for sliders, curveballs, sweepers, and changeups, and if there was one finding that carried through the entire project, it was that this class does not run through fastballs. It runs through what comes after them. Between Bradley's cambio, Volantis's curveball, and Moss's 'UFO' change, pitchers' best pitches are just as often a secondary as they are a fastball.

From there, the series split the class by role and by handedness. The bullpen and starter pieces drew the line between pitchers built for length and pitchers built for one inning at maximum effort, a distinction that mattered more in this class than most because so many of the best arms such as Cozart, Jenkins, Barberi, Hawk, spent 2026 in relief roles that undersell what they might become. The RHP and LHP rankings did the same work by handedness, surfacing just how deep the left-handed class runs behind Volantis, Valincius, and Bowie. And the risers piece tried to look forward, betting on the workload jumps, health, and role changes most likely to make this entire list look different by summer.

Every one of those pieces was really doing the same job from a different angle: building toward this. The tier system is not a tenth opinion stacked on nine others. It is what happens when all of that work gets folded into one place; pitch grades built pitch by pitch, workload and role questions worked out arm by arm, and 53 separate evaluations forced to sit next to each other and get sorted into groups that actually mean something.

That is the part worth sitting with. Every name on this list, in every tier, was watched, graded, and written up individually before it ever became a line in a spreadsheet or a slot in a tier. The AverageFuture column behind these rankings is not a formula pulled from nowhere, it is the sum of

hundreds of individual pitch grades, each one argued out pitch by pitch the way the fastball, breaking ball, and offspeed pieces did in isolation. The tiers are the finish line. The scouting is what actually got this series there.

The 2027 college pitching class will look different by Omaha than it does on this page, and that is the point of doing this every year rather than once. But for right now, at the end of a ten-part project that started with a single scouting report back in June, this is the clearest picture available of where the class stands: headliners, depth, sleepers, and all the work that went into sorting one from the other.

If you have made it this far in this one, thank you for reading these over the past few months. It has been a lot of work and I am working now on building a small portfolio website where all of these articles will be more easily available.